

Birds

And now the **Collared Dove** *Streptopelia Decaocto*



A small, slim long-tailed dove, grey-buff to pinkish-grey overall, with a distinctive black band on its neck.



Its eyes appear to be black but the iris is red, well a red rim to a large black pupil.

Most often seen in pairs – when you see one, expect another. However incubation is done by the female during the night and the male during the day!



Like other pigeons the male mating display is a rapid near-vertical climb and a long glide downward in a circle. With the wings held below the body in an inverted V-shape.

They feed close to humans, seeds, like grain, shoots and insects. There are 990,000 breeding pairs in the UK.

Quite similar to the rarer Turtle Dove which you might see down at Otmoor, maybe in one of the oaks at the start of the bridle path near the gate. Or **hear** it as it sounds like a cat purring.



Birds

This month it's Pigeons and Doves

Pigeons and doves belong to the genus *Columba*. This latin name comes from the Ancient Greek word meaning *diver* – after the birds' swimming motion in the air. They share lots of features and there's no strict division between them. Here are the two we have in the park

First the **Wood Pigeon** *Columba Palumbus*



Its white neck patch and wing feathers make it easy for us to distinguish from the town, feral pigeons.

On take-off and landings its wings clatter noisily.

In the breeding season on its display flight the male climbs with fast, clattering wingbeats and then glides slowly down on stiff wings.



They're gregarious and often feed very close to human habitation on various seeds, berries and buds, with beechmast and acorns in autumn.

Its numbers have increased to 5,400,000 breeding pairs in the UK. Earlier this year the general licences that allow anyone in the UK to kill 16 species of birds including wood pigeons, crows, jays, rooks, jackdaws, magpies, Canada geese and parakeets were revoked. This caused consternation with farmers who now have to apply for a licence.

But what about keeping the numbers down by eating pigeons like we eat chickens? That's another story!



Birds

Beliefs

Pigeons and doves represent peace, purity, faith and fidelity in numerous cultures around the world.

They've given their name to

Pigeon holes were the openings set in a wall or a purpose-built **pigeon** cote in which the birds nested. By 1789, the arrangement of compartments in writing cabinets and offices used to sort and file documents had come to be known as pigeon holes because of their resemblance to



the pigeon cote.



Feral pigeons

As kept in his back garden by the late Len Temple in Ringwood Road.

Why I chose these 2 birds this month is because you can identify both of them without even seeing them. And although I can't hear a lot of birds these days I can certainly hear the pigeons!

The **Wood Pigeon's** call is a **doo-doooh, doo, doo-du doo-doooh, doo, doo-du**

Whenever grandson Cody is around for his breakfast the Wood Pigeon's call is translated as **"take 2 eggs, Cody, take 2 eggs, Cody"**

This is even though, as his uncle has told him, one egg is *enough*.

Because in France one egg is *un oeuf*

The **Collared Dove's** call is a repeated deep **koo-koooo, koo koo-koooo, koo** which roughly translates a bored OUFC supporter repeating a slow **United** over and over again!

Wasn't like that at the Manor back in the eighties!

Risinghurst and Sandhills Parish Council July 2019

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